



However, all this batting frenzy was on good batting pitches against opposition attacks that weren't quite threatening. When the Aussies came last year for The Ashes, though the first ball of the series was driven for a boundary, England lost the first two Test matches. The Aussies quickly reduced the lengths and began to bang the ball in short, and the English batters, who are inherently front-foot players, began to struggle.

One of the tenets of the new regime of McCullum and Stokes is that they will stick by their players, come what may. While this is admirable, it also smacks of closed doors for anyone outside the squad, especially the batters. So despite Jonny Bairstow once again looking totally out of his depth against the Indian spinners, he was persisted with throughout this series with unsurprisingly dire results.

Playing fearlessly is another thing we often

Making a point: "What great fun to watch a young India team demolish an England team that had arrived in India with the usual 'we are doing you a favour' attitude, says the author." GETTYIMAGES

hear. What is there to fear if, despite not delivering, there is a cool retainer cheque waiting for the player? Remove that cushion of comfort whereby if a player is dropped, he goes back to playing only County cricket or Ranji Trophy cricket, and then we will see who is fearless and who is not.

The BCCI must be congratulated for coming up with a scheme that will reward those who make themselves available to play most if not all of the Tests in the year by tripling their match fees. This is entirely Secretary Jay Shah's initiative and needs to be lauded, for sure.

That said, it's a sad state of affairs if a player has to be rewarded for making himself available to play for the country. **It once again boils down to the retainer contracts, where, whether you play or not, your bank manager will beam as he informs you the funds have arrived. The tripling of the match fees will have more effect if the retainers are done away with.** Maybe not fully, but with a minimum of 1 crore plus the reward of playing more Test matches. Then we will see how much workload factor comes in and sundry excuses like weddings of third cousins, birthdays, anniversaries, and such like to miss playing for India.

What really needs doubling, if not tripling, is the Ranji Trophy match fees, along with a slab system of more fees for every 10 matches played, for then not many will make themselves unavailable as there would be good money playing first-class cricket too.

Just to end, in the recently started Tennis Ball Premier League, some players were bought for double the amount that those Vidarbha and Mumbai players who have played every Ranji match this season will get. By all means, make the rich richer, but also look at those hardy souls who sweat and toil for more than 40 days in front of sparse crowds and end up getting 15 lakhs for their efforts.



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